VERNON, HERE WE COME

'Bring back lessons every day from work.'

Excitement was palpable as our first team of about fifty people were ready to leave for Vernon. A commune of hardly 10,000 people then, Vernon in the Upper Normandy region was known outside France only because of the rocket engine-making facility. About 75 km north-east of Paris, it had the quaint charm of an expansive village than a small town. River Seine flowed not-so-quietly; on its serene banks, children played, farmers grew mustard.

In early August, 1974, our engineers K Lakshminarayanan and M K G Nair made a pilot visit to Vernon to arrange accommodation for the team. Once they identified an apartment complex at the St Marcel community, about 10 km from the SEP campus, I went to sign the housing contract. The apartments were of varying sizes, from single-bedroom to four-bedroom facilities. This posed a practical difficulty as most of the scientists opted for smaller houses to save on rent and heating.

I charted out a plan: all the apartments will be in a pool from which each would be allotted on lot. Irrespective of the size of the apartment, the rent would be the same, which was the average. None protested. One of the four-bedroom apartments was converted into our office. As the team leader, I had the privilege of having a room. In another, I got some fifty chairs for the team to meet. I took along two draftsmen, Muthuswamy and T K Lakshmanan, and a personal assistant Unni Paramangalath, who also went through a screening. Adding a photocopier machine, ISRO's first foreign office had just started functioning. H R S Mani, who was in charge of quality control, helped with administration.

Since we were dealing with blueprints of rockets, buying a photocopier in our name would invite a lot of questions. I got it in the name of the Indian embassy. My personal assistant, I was clear, should be most trustworthy, since we would be dealing with sensitive stuff. According to the Government of India rules, any foreign assignment has to recruit